

Born in a middle-class family, Krishna understood the meaning and importance of working on self for the betterment of others from a very young age. His father had lost his own father at an early age, and Krishna, as far as he remembers, had seen his father work day-and-night to ensure his family was not deprived of any necessities. "My father is a self-made man, and in the process of working on himself for his family's well-being, he set an example for us and taught the importance of hard work for being successful," recalls a proud Krishna.

Krishna's parents, young at 99 and 88, live with him and always saw education as a necessity to excel in life. He and his brother were made clear from childhood that they would not compromise on their education. "That was the safety net for the future," they taught early in life.

"Our parents told us, everything apart from education can wait. Belonging to a middle-class family, my father kept a purse that was to be used only for education. While luxuries were not always possible, he never let us struggle for necessities. Our mother, like any other mother in those days, managed home and ensured we were well looked after," says a proud Krishna.

Krishna's father worked with a rubber company which was a major supplier to leading tyre brands of India. Born in Calcutta (now Kolkata), Krishna moved to Kerala with his parents before the start of his schooling. The change of states presented his father with an opportunity to get Krishna admitted into one of the oldest and the then most reputed schools in India, known as CMS High School, in Kottayam.

"I had the good fortune of studying in one of the oldest schools in India, which was established in 1817. I completed my 12th standard from CMS College, which was run by the same school's management. Those days the +2 was in colleges, unlike today," he recalls.

Krishna was one of the brightest students in the school. Always among the toppers in his class, he was also active in sports including cricket and football. His outstanding academic results in the 12th standard helped him

get a seat in the engineering stream. "Those days there were no entrance exams, and you were picked on the basis of merit in your 12th standard. How you scored in Physics, Chemistry, and Maths was what mattered the most during those times," he explains.

Based on his 12th standard results, Krishna got admission to Electronics and Communications engineering degree course in College of Engineering Trivandrum (CET). CET was the only college offering an engineering degree in the E&C stream throughout Kerala then, and only 45 students were selected for the course.

Krishna loves watching sports including cricket, tennis, football, badminton, and chess. However, since his childhood, he has not been able to appreciate sports involving individuals hitting each other like boxing, karate, wrestling, etc. "I still do not like any kind of violence, and that is probably why I chose engineering over a medical degree. I would have had to dissect frogs if I had chosen medicine as a career," shares Krishna jokingly.

Spirituality while engineering

Krishna likes reading, which also relaxes him. He started reading comics in his childhood and is a big-time fan and follower of the popular Tom and Jerry series even now. However, his life completely changed when he read the book titled 'You Can Win' by the motivational speaker and author Shiv Khera. The punchline of the book, 'Winners Don't Do Different Things, They Do Things Differently,' has become the motto of Krishna's life ever since. He mentioned this phrase at least twenty times during our conversation.

"Early in life I learned important things like the need to have command over the English language to succeed. I learnt that there is always a need for being a good communicator and doing things differently instead of doing different things," he explains. He understood the importance of being a good communicator by listening to his teachers. He recalls the difference in teaching methods of his teachers. While all of them had a stronghold over the subjects they were teaching, not all had equally good communication skills. Different teachers, in the words

of Krishna, were teaching differently.

Krishna has read 'You Can Win' more than a dozen times, and every time in a different context. He believes a book can change one's life. Krishna experienced spirituality also the first time through the book 'Art of Man Making' by Swami Chinmayananda ji, which he read by chance during his engineering college days. The best part as a result of being spiritual, as he explains, is the understanding of having less ego so as to be able to learn from anybody.

History is another subject that he seems completely in love with. He probably has read more history books than he has read about Physics, Chemistry, and Math. "Every major event in world history has brought disruptive innovation and birth of new technologies," says Krishna. In fact, if not an engineer, he would have been in the profession of teaching. Krishna, on an average, reads at least one book every month and currently he is reading 'Innovation' by Curtis Carlson and William Wilmot.

"I always believe that the progress in modern-day technology in any country can happen only when academia and industry work very closely. Israel for me is one of the best examples. My eagerness to stay connected with technologists in industries and professors in universities stayed with me always," says Krishna.

The first job and India's first ASIC

Krishna's father saw India struggle for independence. His first paycheck was only fifty rupees, so he taught Krishna the importance of seeking happiness in little things but being ready for everything always.

Krishna recalls how excited his father was on learning about Krishna's first job with Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL). He was excited not just because it was a PSU job, but also because Krishna was getting a chance to serve his motherland. "I was excited to know that I would be joining the R&D team of BEL as I was and am always fascinated by technology. But my father was more excited than me when I told him I was going to work with BEL," Krishna smiles.

The year Krishna joined BEL as a